



STUDY GUIDE FOR



UNITED NATION SECURITY COUNCIL

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I. MANDATE OF THE UNITED NATIONS SECURITY COUNCIL

PURPOSE AND COMPOSITION

The Security Council is one of the six principal organs of the United Nations. Article 24 of the Charter assigns it primary responsibility for the maintenance of international peace and security. The Council's composition and voting rules are established in Chapter V.

Feature	What delegates should know
15 members	5 permanent + 10 elected
P5	China, France, Russian Federation, United Kingdom, United States
Elected members	10 states elected by the General Assembly for two-year terms
Voting	9 votes for procedural matters; 9 including concurring P5 votes for substantive matters
Decisions	Members agree to accept and carry out Security Council decisions under Article 25
Meetings	Public meetings, consultations, informal formats and other procedures

WHY THE COUNCIL IS DIFFERENT FROM A QA COMMITTEE

The Council is smaller, faster and more power-sensitive. A persuasive speech is useful, but a proposal must account for veto politics, mandate limits, state consent, implementation capacity and the interests of actors outside the room.

THE COUNCIL'S CENTRAL TENSION

The Council must respond to threats while operating inside a political system where the strongest states may disagree. The result is often compromise: a resolution may be less ambitious than the initial draft but more implementable because it preserves minimum consensus.

2. FUNDING OF THE UNITED NATIONS SECURITY COUNCIL

HOW THE COUNCIL IS FUNDED

The Security Council does not operate as an independently funded institution with its own standalone budget. Its authority is exercised through the wider United Nations financial system, while specific Council-authorized activities, especially peacekeeping operations and special political missions, are financed through mechanisms approved by the General Assembly

PEACEKEEPING FINANCING

Under Article 17 of the Charter, the General Assembly considers and approves the Organization's budget and apportions expenses among Member States. Peacekeeping operations are financed separately from the regular UN budget through assessments, with Member States collectively responsible for the expenses. The scale for peacekeeping gives the permanent members a higher share because of their special responsibility for international peace and security.



SPECIAL POLITICAL MISSIONS AND IMPLEMENTATION

Special political missions are generally financed through the UN regular budget. For delegates, the practical lesson is that a Council resolution should not simply authorize an ambitious mechanism: it should identify the implementing actor, reporting structure, personnel or technical capacity required, and a realistic funding pathway.

I.I. INTRODUCTION TO THE AGENDA – OPEN AGENDA

THE FIVE-PART FILTER

1. **Mandate:** Does the issue plausibly threaten international peace and security or create serious cross-border effects?
2. **Council relevance:** Can the UNSC add value beyond what another UN organ already does?
3. **Actionability:** Are there realistic tools available—mediation, sanctions, mandate changes, monitoring, authorization, humanitarian measures?
4. **Political feasibility:** Is there a pathway to nine votes and, where substantive, sufficient P5 acceptance?
5. **Implementation:** Who will actually carry out the decision?

Applying the filter is harder than listing it. A crisis can satisfy the mandate test on paper while failing the political-feasibility test in practice: many humanitarian emergencies plausibly threaten peace and security, but a topic involving a permanent member's direct interests, or one where another organ already has clear lead responsibility, may not be where the Council can add distinctive value. Strong delegates apply all five criteria together rather than stopping once the first one is satisfied.

The actionability test deserves particular care in an open-agenda committee. It is not enough that the Council has used a tool such as sanctions or peacekeeping mandates before; delegates should be able to



name which specific tool fits the crisis at hand and explain, in concrete terms, who would implement it, with what resources, and under whose authority. A resolution that cannot answer this in a moderated caucus is vulnerable to the same drafting weaknesses covered later in this guide's implementation and QARMA sections.

Delegates should also test their chosen crisis against recent Council practice: has the issue appeared on the Council's agenda before, and if so, what happened to earlier resolutions or presidential statements on it? A topic with a documented history of Council engagement, existing reporting mechanisms or a standing sanctions committee is usually easier to build a workable resolution around than one the Council has never addressed, because delegates can extend or adjust existing tools rather than inventing an entirely new mandate from nothing.

HIGH-VALUE OPEN-AGENDA THEMES

- Armed conflict and ceasefire implementation.
- Protection of civilians and humanitarian access.
- Sanctions evasion and illicit arms flows.
- Peacekeeping transitions and mission drawdown.
- Cross-border terrorism and organized armed groups.
- Maritime security and attacks on shipping.
- Conflict prevention, mediation and regional diplomacy.
- Post-conflict institution-building where instability has regional consequences.

WHAT TO AVOID

Avoid choosing an issue merely because it is famous. A good UNSC topic is one where you can explain the threat, identify a Council tool, identify relevant states and propose a mechanism that could plausibly operate on the ground.



I.2. KEY TERMINOLOGIES RELATED TO THE AGENDA

COLLECTIVE SECURITY

The principle that threats to international peace and security are treated as a concern of the international community rather than solely as a bilateral dispute.

P5

The five permanent members of the Security Council: China, France, the Russian Federation, the United Kingdom and the United States.

E10

The ten elected members of the Security Council, serving two-year terms.

VETO

The ability of a permanent member to prevent adoption of a substantive draft resolution by voting against it; abstention by a permanent member does not itself constitute a veto.

CHAPTER VI

Charter framework for the peaceful settlement of disputes, primarily involving investigation, recommendations and facilitation of settlement.

CHAPTER VII

Charter framework allowing the Council, after determining a threat to the peace, breach of the peace or act of aggression, to adopt enforcement measures.

ARTICLE 39

The threshold provision under Chapter VII through which the Council determines the existence of a threat to the peace, breach of the peace or act of aggression.

ARTICLE 41

Provides for measures not involving the use of armed force, including interruption of economic relations and communications and other restrictive measures.

ARTICLE 42

Allows action by air, sea or land forces when Article 41 measures would be inadequate or have proved inadequate.

PEACEKEEPING

UN operations mandated by the Security Council that support ceasefires, political processes and civilian protection; they rely on Member States for personnel and resources and are not a standing UN army.

PROTECTION OF CIVILIANS (POC)

Measures intended to prevent or reduce harm to civilians in situations of armed conflict, including through political, humanitarian and, where authorized, security tools.

HUMANITARIAN ACCESS

The ability of humanitarian actors to reach people in need safely, rapidly and without arbitrary obstruction, consistent with applicable international law.

TARGETED SANCTIONS

Restrictive measures directed at specified individuals, entities, sectors or activities rather than broad restrictions on an entire population.

CEASEFIRE

An agreed or ordered suspension of hostilities. For Council purposes, a ceasefire clause is stronger when it specifies verification, reporting and consequences for violations.



FREEDOM OF NAVIGATION

The legally protected ability of vessels to navigate in accordance with applicable international law; disruption of major maritime routes can create wider international peace and security consequences.

DECONFLICTION

Arrangements designed to reduce the risk of accidental or unintended military confrontation, particularly where multiple armed actors operate in close proximity.

SANCTIONS EVASION

Actions intended to circumvent Council-imposed restrictive measures, including illicit financial channels, front companies, false documentation or prohibited transfers.

EXIT STRATEGY

Defined conditions and steps for modifying, transitioning or ending a Council mechanism or mission once its objectives have been met or circumstances materially change.

1.3. HISTORICAL CONTEXT

FROM THE LEAGUE TO THE UN

The Security Council's institutional design emerged from the failure of the League of Nations system to prevent major-power conflict and the experience of the Second World War. The UN Charter therefore gave the Security Council primary responsibility for international peace and security and created a structure in which the major powers would participate directly in collective-security decisions. The permanent-member veto was a political compromise intended to prevent the organization from taking enforcement action against a major power without that power's concurrence.



This history explains a recurring tension in Council practice: the Council possesses unusually strong formal tools, but their use depends on political agreement among States with very different strategic interests. The result is that UNSC effectiveness cannot be assessed solely by the wording of a resolution. Implementation, political will, cooperation from States and the Council's ability to maintain unity are equally important.

The Security Council was designed after the Second World War to provide a stronger collective-security mechanism than the League of Nations had achieved. The Charter combines sovereign equality with differentiated responsibility for the five permanent members.

The historical practice matters because the boundaries are not merely theoretical. The Council has used Chapter VII for sanctions regimes, tribunals, arms restrictions and other measures, while also invoking Chapter VII in connection with peace operations. Delegates should therefore distinguish the legal basis of a measure from the political purpose for which it is adopted.

When the Council determines a threat to the peace, breach of the peace or act of aggression, Chapter VII provides stronger tools. Article 41 allows measures not involving armed force, including economic and diplomatic restrictions. Article 42 concerns action involving armed force when Article 41 measures are inadequate. Regional organizations can play roles in peace and security, but their activities interact with Security Council authority. The relationship is especially important for mediation, peace operations, sanctions implementation and regional stabilization. The Council's practice has changed markedly since the Cold War, and delegates should be able to speak to that trajectory. The veto has been cast more than 300 times since the Council's first resolution in January 1946, but its pattern has shifted substantially: the Soviet Union cast the overwhelming majority of vetoes in the Council's first decade, largely to block new UN membership applications, while the United States has used the veto most frequently since the 1970s, predominantly on resolutions concerning Israel and Palestine. A brief window of intensive P5 cooperation followed the end of the Cold War, most visibly in the Council's unified response authorizing action after Iraq's 1990 invasion of Kuwait, and several multi-year stretches through the 1990s passed without any veto at all.



That cooperative period also produced a major expansion in what the Council was willing to do under Chapter VII: the ad hoc international criminal tribunals for the former Yugoslavia (1993) and Rwanda (1994), an increasingly assertive use of sanctions regimes, and peacekeeping mandates that began to include explicit civilian-protection language rather than pure ceasefire monitoring. Veto use rose again after 2011, driven substantially by Russian and Chinese vetoes on Syria, illustrating that the Council's tools have not fundamentally changed since the Charter was signed, but the political conditions for using them have continued to fluctuate.

I.4. RELEVANT INTERNATIONAL AND REGIONAL FRAMEWORKS

CHAPTER VI – PEACEFUL SETTLEMENT

Chapter VI focuses on peaceful settlement of disputes. The Council can investigate situations, call upon parties to settle disputes and recommend procedures or terms. Chapter VI measures are generally recommendation-oriented.

CHAPTER VII – THREATS TO PEACE

Chapter VII is the legal framework most closely associated with the Council's enforcement authority. Article 39 provides the threshold determination of a threat to the peace, breach of the peace or act of aggression. Article 41 permits measures not involving armed force, including sanctions, while Article 42 concerns action involving armed force when Article 41 measures are inadequate. The Council's Repertoire documents how these provisions have actually been interpreted and applied over time.



CHAPTER VIII – REGIONAL ARRANGEMENTS

UNITED NATIONS CHARTER

The UN Charter is the primary legal framework for Security Council action. Article 24 assigns the Council primary responsibility for the maintenance of international peace and security; Article 25 requires Member States to accept and carry out Council decisions. Chapter VI addresses peaceful settlement, while Chapter VII provides enforcement powers. Chapter VIII recognizes a role for regional arrangements in maintaining peace and security.

INTERNATIONAL HUMANITARIAN LAW AND PROTECTION OF CIVILIANS

Where armed conflict is involved, Council action should be read alongside the rules of international humanitarian law concerning distinction, proportionality, precautions in attack, protection of civilians and civilian objects, and humanitarian relief. Resolution drafting should avoid creating mechanisms that weaken these protections.

WOMEN, PEACE AND SECURITY

Security Council Resolution 1325 (2000) and the subsequent Women, Peace and Security resolutions establish a framework for women's participation in peace processes and for addressing conflict-related risks to women and girls. Delegates should consider participation, protection and prevention when designing peace and security measures.



MARITIME SECURITY AND THE LAW OF THE SEA

When a crisis involves shipping or chokepoints such as the Strait of Hormuz, delegates should distinguish Security Council authority from the separate rules of international maritime law. Council measures should address navigation, civilian shipping and escalation risks without treating maritime questions as purely military issues.

NUCLEAR NON-PROLIFERATION AND IAEA VERIFICATION

Where armed conflict is involved, Council action should be read alongside the rules of international humanitarian law concerning distinction, proportionality, precautions in attack, protection of civilians and civilian objects, and humanitarian relief. Resolution drafting should avoid creating mechanisms that weaken these protections.

REGIONAL ORGANIZATIONS AND CHAPTER VIII

CHAPTER VIII IN PRACTICE

Regional organizations have become increasingly important partners in conflict prevention, mediation and peace operations. Chapter VIII recognizes a role for regional arrangements, and Security Council practice includes cases where the Council has authorized or supported regional operations and requested reporting from regional organizations. The African Union is particularly significant in this regard because many African conflicts require both continental political engagement and international legitimacy/resources.

The relationship is not simply hierarchical. Regional organizations may have greater political familiarity, proximity and legitimacy with the parties to a conflict, while the UN can provide broader diplomatic legitimacy, financing mechanisms or authorization under the Charter. Effective cooperation therefore depends on



coordination rather than assuming that one institution can replace the other. Regional organizations can provide proximity, political legitimacy and specialized knowledge. The African Union, European Union, Arab League, ASEAN-related mechanisms and other regional structures have different legal bases and capabilities.

WHY REGIONAL OWNERSHIP MATTERS

- Neighbouring states often understand local political and economic incentives better.
- Regional mediators may have access to parties unavailable to distant actors.
- Regional organizations can support ceasefire monitoring or stabilization.
- Regional sanctions and diplomatic pressure can complement UN action.

THE COORDINATION PROBLEM

Multiple mediators can create duplication or contradictory incentives. A strong Council resolution should therefore specify coordination channels, reporting arrangements and division of labour where appropriate.

ARTICLE 41 MEASURES

Security Council sanctions have evolved substantially. Earlier regimes sometimes imposed broad economic restrictions, while later practice increasingly emphasized targeted measures against particular individuals, entities, commodities or activities. The Council currently describes sanctions as one of its enforcement tools under Article 41 and notes that they may include arms embargoes, travel bans and financial restrictions.

The historical evolution also reflects lessons about humanitarian effects and implementation. Sanctions are not automatically effective simply because they are legally binding. Their impact depends on monitoring, domestic implementation, exemptions, enforcement capacity and the willingness of States and private actors to comply. The Council's own practice recognizes that sanctions are generally more effective when embedded in a broader strategy of peacekeeping, peacemaking and peacebuilding.



Sanctions are among the Council's most frequently used non-military tools. They can include asset freezes, travel bans, arms embargoes, commodity restrictions and other targeted measures. The Council often creates sanctions committees and expert panels to support implementation and monitoring.

I.5. CORE PRINCIPLES

CHARTER LEGALITY AND MANDATE FIT

Every operative clause should be traceable to a Security Council competence and an identifiable legal or political basis. Delegates should distinguish recommendations from binding decisions and avoid assigning powers to the Council that belong to other UN organs or Member States.

SOVEREIGNTY AND PEACEFUL SETTLEMENT

Council action should respect sovereignty, territorial integrity and political independence while recognizing that serious threats to international peace and security may require collective action under the Charter.

NECESSITY, PROPORTIONALITY AND CIVILIAN PROTECTION

Security measures should be calibrated to the threat and designed to minimize foreseeable harm to civilians and civilian infrastructure. "Protection" should be translated into concrete tasks, resources and monitoring.

CONSENT, IMPARTIALITY AND OPERATIONAL CLARITY IN PEACEKEEPING

Peacekeeping mandates should be matched to available capabilities and political conditions. Delegates should not assume the UN possesses a standing army; Member States provide personnel, equipment and financing.



ACCOUNTABILITY AND EVIDENCE

Council measures should be based on credible evidence, clear listing or designation criteria where sanctions are used, reporting arrangements, and review mechanisms that permit correction of error.

REGIONAL OWNERSHIP AND COORDINATION

Regional actors can provide proximity, mediation channels and political leverage. Council resolutions should define how regional and UN efforts coordinate rather than creating parallel or contradictory mechanisms.

WOMEN, PEACE AND SECURITY

Peace processes are stronger when women participate meaningfully in prevention, mediation, negotiation and implementation, while conflict-related risks to women and girls are explicitly addressed.

REVIEW, ADAPTABILITY AND EXIT

Every major mechanism should have a reporting cycle, review point, measurable indicators and conditions for modification, transition or termination.

1.6. CONTEMPORARY CASE STUDIES AND VIOLATIONS

MONUSCO

The UN mission in the Democratic Republic of the Congo illustrates the complexity of a long-running operation with civilian-protection and stabilization tasks. The Council must balance mandate ambition with host-state consent, armed-group dynamics, regional politics, mission capacity and eventual transition.



AFRICAN UNION-UN COOPERATION

Hybrid and jointly supported mechanisms in Africa demonstrate both the potential and complexity of partnership. Financing, command arrangements, political alignment and accountability must be addressed rather than assumed.

ISIL/AL-QAIDA SANCTIONS

The 1267/1989/2253 regime demonstrates how the Council can combine targeted assets freezes, travel bans and arms embargoes with a sanctions list, monitoring team and delisting procedures. It also illustrates the continuing challenge of due process, evidence, implementation and changing threat networks.

RWANDA, 1994

The Rwandan genocide is one of the most important historical cases for understanding the consequences of inadequate international response. In 1994, mass killing unfolded while the UN peacekeeping operation in Rwanda, UNAMIR, operated under a limited mandate and faced severe political and operational constraints. The international response failed to prevent or halt the genocide, and the experience became a lasting reference point in debates over civilian protection, early warning and the responsibilities of the international community.

SREBRENICA, 1995

Srebrenica demonstrated another dimension of the protection problem. The UN had declared Srebrenica a safe area and deployed UNPROFOR personnel, yet Bosnian Serb forces captured the enclave in July 1995 and subsequently murdered thousands of Bosniak men and boys. The episode exposed the gap that can arise between a political designation such as a “safe area” and the resources and authority required to enforce that protection. Srebrenica illustrates the danger of declaring a protected area without the political, military and operational capacity required to protect civilians. It is particularly useful for studying mandate credibility and the relationship between peacekeeping and coercive force.



LIBYA — AUTHORIZATION AND UNINTENDED CONSEQUENCES

The 2011 Libya case is frequently used to illustrate the difference between authorization and implementation. Resolution 1973 authorized Member States to take “all necessary measures” to protect civilians and established a no-fly zone, while excluding an occupying foreign force. The intervention contributed to the collapse of Muammar Gaddafi’s government, but Libya subsequently experienced prolonged political fragmentation and insecurity.

UNMIS / UNAMID / SUDAN EXPERIENCE

Sudan-related missions demonstrate how mandates evolve as political conditions change. The Council must think about transition, successor mechanisms and what happens after a mission closes. “Exit strategy” should not mean simply leaving; it should identify which national, regional or UN mechanisms inherit residual responsibilities.

UKRAINE — VETO POLITICS AND COUNCIL PARALYSIS

The Ukraine case demonstrates the structural significance of the veto. Russia, as a permanent member, can block substantive Council decisions that it opposes, even where other members support stronger Council action. This does not mean the UN system becomes completely inactive: the General Assembly, Secretary-General, humanitarian agencies, courts and other institutions can continue to act within their respective mandates. But it does illustrate the limits of the Security Council when a permanent member is directly involved in a conflict or strongly contests the proposed response. Historically, this reflects the basic political bargain embedded in the Charter. The veto was designed to ensure that enforcement action by the organization would not proceed against the wishes of a major power. That bargain protects the Council’s participation of the major powers while simultaneously creating the possibility of paralysis.



Ukraine demonstrates a central institutional problem: when a permanent member is directly implicated in a conflict, the Council may struggle to adopt substantive measures because of veto dynamics. Delegates should distinguish what the Council can do collectively from what other UN organs, regional organizations or states can do separately.

CASE STUDY: 2026 UNITED STATES–IRAN CONFLICT

The 2026 United States–Iran conflict is a particularly relevant contemporary case for an open-agenda Security Council because it combines questions of the use of force, self-defence, regional spillover, civilian protection, maritime security, sanctions, nuclear verification, mediation and Council unity. The United States reported to the Security Council that it commenced combat operations against Iran on 28 February 2026 pursuant to Article 51 and its claimed inherent right of self-defence. Iran has disputed the legality of the U.S. and Israeli actions and invoked its own Article 51 position.

The conflict quickly acquired a wider regional dimension. Iranian missile and drone attacks affected Bahrain, Kuwait, Oman, Qatar, Saudi Arabia, the United Arab Emirates and Jordan. On 11 March 2026, the Security Council adopted Resolution 2817 by a vote of 13 in favour, with China and the Russian Federation abstaining. The resolution condemned Iranian attacks, demanded their cessation, reaffirmed navigational rights and condemned attempts to obstruct international navigation through the Strait of Hormuz. Diplomacy produced a significant but fragile development in June. The Islamabad Memorandum of Understanding between the United States and Iran created a framework for de-escalation, while Pakistan and Qatar facilitated follow-up talks. The subsequent roadmap included technical discussions on nuclear issues, sanctions, monitoring and dispute resolution, as well as communication and deconfliction arrangements intended to reduce incidents and support safe commercial passage through the Strait of Hormuz.

By early September 2026, however, the conflict had escalated again. Reuters reported renewed U.S. strikes on Iran beginning 1 September, followed by Iranian attacks on U.S.-linked positions and regional targets. On 5 September, U.S. and Iranian forces exchanged fire near Iranian waters, and the United States struck t



three Iranian vessels after Iran launched ballistic missiles at two U.S. Navy ships. These developments demonstrate how quickly a partially negotiated ceasefire or de-escalation framework can unravel when verification, compFor MUN delegates, the central questions are not simply which side is “right.” The case should be analyzed through the Council’s actual mandate: What evidence establishes a threat to international peace and security? How should competing Article 51 claims be assessed? What mechanism could verify a ceasefire? How can freedom of navigation be protected without widening the war? What sanctions, humanitarian exemptions and monitoring arrangements are realistic? How can nuclear verification be linked to diplomacy? Which regional actors can mediate? And what consequences can the Council credibly attach to non-compliance without making escalation more likely? liance and dispute-resolution mechanisms are insufficiently trusted or enforced.

I.7. CHALLENGES IN THE IMPLEMENTATION AND ENFORCEMENT

VETO POLITICS AND COUNCIL PARALYSIS

The Council can adopt strong language yet fail to act when a permanent member’s interests are directly implicated. This creates a mandate-capacity gap between what the Council formally decides and what it can politically enforce.

MANDATE-CAPACITY GAPS

Peacekeeping and political missions depend on personnel, financing, host-state cooperation and operational capacity. A mandate that promises more than these resources can support risks creating expectations that cannot be met.



SANCTIONS EVASION AND UNINTENDED HUMANITARIAN EFFECTS

Sanctions may be circumvented through illicit networks while legitimate banks, insurers and humanitarian organizations may over-comply because of legal or reputational risk. Resolution 2664's standing humanitarian exemption illustrates the Council's attempt to reduce such effects, but implementation remains complex.

REGIONAL COORDINATION PROBLEMS

Multiple mediators or regional actors can produce duplication, contradictory incentives or competing political tracks. Council resolutions should define communication channels, reporting arrangements and division of labour.

VERIFICATION AND ACCOUNTABILITY

A ceasefire, sanctions regime or political agreement cannot be reliably enforced without credible information. The Council must identify who verifies compliance, how information is reported and what happens when evidence is disputed.

EMERGING TECHNOLOGIES AND CHANGING WARFARE

Drones, cyber operations, autonomous systems, commercial satellite imagery and information operations can alter conflict dynamics faster than Council procedures adapt. Resolutions should focus on durable principles and verifiable conduct rather than narrow technology labels.

THE HUMANITARIAN DILEMMA

Sanctions and security measures can pressure armed actors but may also affect civilians if poorly designed. Banks, insurers and humanitarian organizations frequently respond to legal uncertainty by over-complying: declining to process any transaction connected to a sanctioned country, entity or region rather than assessing individual risk. This is the same de-risking dynamic that affects FIUs



elsewhere in the financial system, and it can quietly strip humanitarian operations of banking access even where an exemption technically exists on paper.

RESOLUTION 2664 — A STANDING HUMANITARIAN EXEMPTION

On 9 December 2022 the Council adopted resolution 2664, creating a standing humanitarian exemption that applies across nearly all United Nations sanctions regimes rather than requiring a bespoke carve-out for each new measure. The resolution, adopted 14 in favour with one abstention (India), provides that the provision, processing or payment of funds and the provision of goods and services necessary to ensure the timely delivery of humanitarian assistance or to support other activities that support basic human needs are permitted and do not violate Council-imposed asset freezes. For the 1267/1989/2253 ISIL (Da'esh) and Al-Qaida regime the exemption initially applied for a two-year period; the Council subsequently reaffirmed its continued application through resolution 2761 (2024). The exemption is deliberately not unconditional. Humanitarian providers are still expected to use reasonable efforts to minimize any benefit to designated individuals or entities, and the resolution requires the UN Emergency Relief Coordinator to brief the relevant sanctions committees roughly once a year on how the exemption is being used in practice. This pairing of a broad legal permission with a recurring accountability mechanism is a useful drafting model: delegates designing or reviewing a sanctions regime can build humanitarian protection in from the outset rather than negotiating waivers case by case after harm has already occurred.

WHY UNINTENDED EFFECTS STILL OCCUR

Even with a standing exemption in place, unintended effects can persist because individual banks and private companies, not the Council itself, ultimately decide whether to process a given transaction, and many still choose caution over risk. A well-drafted resolution should therefore go beyond the legal exemption and address practical implementation: clear guidance for financial institutions and



humanitarian actors, accessible points of contact for questions about a specific transaction or partner, and periodic review of whether the exemption is functioning as intended on the ground.

I.8. THE WAY FORWARD: PROPOSED MEASURES AND RECOMMENDATIONS

LAYERED COUNCIL RESOLUTIONS

Structure action in layers: immediate civilian protection and de-escalation; a political process; monitoring and verification; resources and implementation; then transition or exit.

EARLY WARNING AND PREVENTIVE DIPLOMACY

Strengthen reporting, regional consultation and preventive diplomacy before violence reaches the point at which only coercive tools appear politically available.

CEASEFIRE VERIFICATION

Where a ceasefire is proposed, establish a verification actor, reporting schedule, incident-definition standard, communications channel and consequences for material violations.

TARGETED SANCTIONS WITH SAFEGUARDS

Use clear listing criteria, humanitarian exemptions, review and delisting procedures, monitoring of evasion and periodic assessments of civilian impact.

REGIONAL MEDIATION

Give credible regional actors defined roles in mediation, deconfliction, monitoring and implementation while maintaining Council oversight where appropriate.



REALISTIC PEACEKEEPING MANDATES

Match mandates to troop and police contributions, financing, host-state consent, rules of engagement and achievable political objectives.

WOMEN, PEACE AND SECURITY INTEGRATION

Require meaningful participation of women in peace processes and include gender-responsive protection and recovery measures.

REVIEW AND EXIT MECHANISMS

Set measurable benchmarks, reporting dates and review clauses so that Council measures can be modified, renewed, transitioned or terminated as conditions change.

1.9. QARMA – QUESTIONS A RESOLUTION MUST ANSWER

QUESTIONS A RESOLUTION MUST ANSWER

1. When a state invokes Article 51 self-defence, what criteria should the Security Council use to determine whether the use of force remains necessary, proportionate, and legally justified?
2. How should the Security Council balance state sovereignty and non-intervention against its responsibility to protect civilians when a government is unwilling or unable to prevent widespread atrocities?
3. Should the veto power of the permanent members be restricted in situations involving mass atrocities or grave threats to international peace, or would such restrictions undermine the political reality on which the Council depends?



4. When sanctions fail to change the behaviour of their intended targets but continue to impose economic and humanitarian costs on civilians, should the Council strengthen, redesign, or terminate them?

5. How can the Security Council remain effective when the permanent members themselves have competing strategic interests in the conflict under consideration—and what mechanisms can prevent geopolitical rivalry from producing Council paralysis?

6. When a ceasefire repeatedly collapses, at what point should the Council move from diplomatic pressure toward enforcement measures, and how can it prevent such enforcement from triggering a wider conflict?

7. How should the Council respond when it authorizes a peacekeeping mission to protect civilians but Member States fail to provide the personnel, funding, equipment, or mandate necessary for the mission to fulfil that responsibility?

8. How can the Council guarantee humanitarian access in active conflicts when parties deliberately obstruct aid, without allowing humanitarian mechanisms to be exploited for military or political advantage?

9. In conflicts involving strategically vital international waterways such as the Strait of Hormuz, how should the Council protect freedom of navigation and global commerce without turning maritime security measures into another source of military escalation?

10. Should the Security Council prioritize legally and morally ideal solutions or politically achievable ones when consensus among major powers is required—and where should it draw the line between pragmatic compromise and unacceptable inaction?



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